



▲ THE DOME-SHAPED STUPA INSIDE THE GREAT CHAITYA

Babylon

Location near Al-Hillah, Iraq

In the first half of the 6th century BCE, the ancient city of Babylon on the Euphrates River was spectacularly rebuilt by King Nebuchadnezzar II to become one of the most celebrated cities in the Near East. The city was laid out on a grid pattern, with the huge temple of Marduk at its heart. Its precincts also contained the great ziggurat of Babylon, which is thought to have been the prototype of the Tower of Babel. Nebuchadnezzar refurbished temples and built vast new city walls, canals, a moat, and a palace

with 250 rooms. He is also thought to have created the Hanging Gardens of Babylon, one of the seven wonders of the ancient world. According to ancient sources, the terraces of the ziggurat rose to a considerable height and were maintained by an ingenious irrigation system. Babylon fell to the Persian king Cyrus the Great in 539 BCE, never to regain its former glory.

Pasargadae

Location near Shiraz, Iran

Pasargadae was founded as the dynastic capital of the Achaemenid Empire under King Cyrus the

Great, who reigned between 559 and 530 BCE. Despite its location in the arid plains of southern Iran, Cyrus created wonderful lawns and flowerbeds, maintained by impressive water systems. Historians believe that his residential palace occupied an area of around 7,000 square ft (650 square m). Among its distinctive features was an imposing central hall with rows of massive columns, the bases of which still remain. However, arguably the most striking monument in the city is Cyrus's massive, austere limestone mausoleum, built in around 500 BCE. More than 33 ft (10 m) high, it is raised on a plinth and accessed by six steps.

Tomb of Darius I

Location Naqsh-e-Rustam, Iran

The tomb of the fourth Persian king of the Achaemenid Empire, Darius I, was cut from the cliffs at Naqsh-e-Rustam, near Persepolis, around 485 BCE. It is distinctive for its richly decorated facade, carved out of a rock in the shape of a cross. Various impressive reliefs feature on the cross, including that of a palace, resting on a throne-bench supported by 30 throne bearers. The figure of Darius also appears on a platform in front of a fire altar, gesturing to a winged figure above him, thought to be the deity Ahura Mazda. By